❖ SPIO – Stateless Person of Indian Origin, those citizens who do not have documents to substantiate their origination as Indian.

The Indian government recognises the significance of Indian Diaspora, as it has brought economic, financial and global recognition. These citizens have been away from India but are striving to make India shine on the global arena.

In the period after India became free, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru pursued a policy of "active dissociation" from the Indian diaspora. He was concerned about the impact of connecting with and advocating for, this diaspora on the sovereignty of host countries. It was under the regime of Rajiv Gandhi that there was a boost in the diaspora policy. He offered support at Fiji Indian crisis in 1986. Besides, having realized Indian diaspora as a strategic asset, he took administrative measures to establish the Indian Overseas department in 1984.

The policy of reaching out to the Indian diaspora began during the leadership of Atal Bihari Vajpayee. During his tenure as the Prime Minister, the Pravasi Bharatiya Divas was first launched in 2003. It is to be celebrated on 9th of January which marks the day when Mahatma Gandhi returned to India from South Africa. The government planned to celebrate it annually by holding events including conferring awards on the prominent members of the Indian diaspora. The initiatives undertaken by the Indian government during last two decades has bolstered the role and significance of Indian diasporic community in the development of the country, in addition to attracting global investment, aids and technology. India's diaspora has sent $79 billion back home, retaining its position as the world's top recipient of remittances.

Tamil Diaspora

The Tamil Diaspora refers to the people who emigrated from their native lands in Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Sri Lanka. They are spread over fifty countries across the world in South East Asia, Oceania, the Americas and the Caribbean, Europe, Middle East and Africa. Throughout ancient history, the Tamils have been seafarers with a strong interest in exploring beyond their lands. The Tamils hence have a long history of overseas migration.

The early settlement patterns could be traced to sugarcane plantations in Mauritius, Jamaica, Trinidad and Tobago, Suriname, Guyana, rubber estates and railways in Malaysia, coffee and tea plantations in Sri lanka. In addition to being taken as labour, there were voluntary emigrants who took up clerical, administrative and military duties. It is these emigrants who gradually became dominant in trade and finance in South East Asia, particularly in Myanmar, Singapore, Malaysia and South Africa.

Status of Tamil around the world



1. Countries where Tamil is an official language are Singapore, Sri Lanka.
2. Countries where Tamil is Recognized as Minority Language are Canada, Malaysia, Mauritius and Seychelles, South Africa, Reunion and France.

The modern Tamil diaspora accounts for around 3.5 million people who voluntarily migrated as skilled professionals to several countries across the world which includes Singapore, the United Kingdom and the United States. Singapore has a dedicated Tamil newspaper, Tamil TV channel and radio for the promotion of the language.

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